University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

7,245 | 8,234: Grand Challenge: Corporate Sustainability Management

ECTS credits: 4

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Active participation, Analog, Individual work individual grade (10%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (35%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (25%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (30%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,234,1.00 Grand Challenge: Corporate Sustainability Management -- English -- Ströhle Judith

Course information

Prerequisites

The course has no specific prerequisites, but an interest in sustainability management is desirable.

IMPORTANT:
The course is structured in one key block, over a period of 6 weeks. As this course will be over a duration of only six weeks and from the beginning there will be interactive- and graded components, **we will not accept any new students to join after the first session**.

Please also note that you can take the course "7,245 - Grand Challenge: Corporate Sustainability Management" only **once** during your study programme. In other words, you cannot under any circumstances take this course both in fall and spring semester.

Learning objectives

- Gain an understanding of the ecological planetary boundaries (such as climate change and biodiversity loss) and social shortfalls and how these are connected to business
- Learn about sustainability business models and frameworks and know how to apply these in practice at a strategic and operational level
- Recognize strategic risks and (innovative) opportunities generated from sustainability, and how companies can manage these
- Examine the multiple tensions that arise among a firm's stakeholders for sustainability demands, and how firms manage this process
- Learn to use and analyze sustainability data, and assess data for relevance, reliability and rigor
- Critically evaluate concepts and ideas, synthesize arguments, and reconcile divergent perspectives to identify strategic sustainability solutions available to companies

Content

The course starts out by taking a look at the pressure human activity is placing on the Earth's natural systems, including climate change and biodiversity loss, and social challenges that have arisen as a result of industrialization and its acceleration in the last 70 years. We will then take a look at regulatory, industry, consumer, and other pressures that spur companies to

address sustainability challenges, followed by an introduction of the major business models and frameworks companies use in practice. We consider how businesses have moved from a 'triple bottom line' approach to a circular economy in which business is embedded in the larger social and ecological systems. Students will gain insight into different businesses and industries and how companies formulate sustainability strategies, including managing their supply chain and engaging stakeholders. We will also look at how companies govern and monitor their sustainability activities.

The course is designed to be highly interactive in order to promote students' ability to get involved and foster their reflection and critical thinking capacity. We will take a blended-learning approach that follows a flipped classroom design. That means you will be expected to do a significant amount of self-preparation every week, ahead of the class based on material provided through an online blog and supplementary readings. The classroom setting will be used as a seminar, workshop, debate and tutorial to exchange ideas, clarify concepts, and think of solutions. The in-class experience will require both individual and group contributions by students. Some portions of the course will rely on student-driven activities and you will be asked to design such activities and lead them for in-class implementation. For this reason, class attendance and participation are critical and reflect a high proportion of your overall grade.

Where possible, we use a real-life case analysis for the group projects. This means that your analysis of the problem(s) presented and the solutions you design may shape how an organization implements sustainability going forwarding, providing you with practical experience in a classroom setting.

Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

The course is structured in one key block, over a period of 6 weeks. As this course will be over a duration of only six weeks and from the beginning there will be interactive- and graded components, we will not accept any new students to join the class after the first session.

Each class is split into two sessions, half of the class time is dedicated for a **flipped classroom format**, in which students play a driving role to direct classroom activities. In the other session, the professor will take the lead, supported by guest speakers (where relevant). In addition, some classroom time will be used to workshop the group projects. All classes will be highly interactive.

Literature

Will be provided in the course via the Canvas platform.

Additional information

Judith Stroehle is Assitant Professor of Sustainability Governance at the Institute for the Environment and Economy, as well as the Institute for Accounting, Control, and Auditing, both at the University of St. Gallen, Switzerland. Her research focusses on exploring the role of accounting, measurement and governance for the sustainability transition.

Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Active participation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Synchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	10%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Class participation

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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2. Examination sub part (2/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	35%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Case study presentation

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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3. Examination sub part (3/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous

Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	25%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Flipped Classroom

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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4. Examination sub part (4/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	30%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Reflection paper

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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Content

The following four categories will count towards your final grade. Further detailed guidance will be made available to you on StudyNet. Please make sure to read this guidance before you contact your instructor with questions. Any questions about this may be raised in class so that others can benefit from the answers also.

Group work:

a. Case study presentation 35%
b. Flipped classroom 25%

Individual:

a. Reflection essay 30%
b. Participation 10%

Literature

The relevant literature will be provided via Study Net and the online blog platform (www.csmathsg.com) and will be discussed during the first class.

Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).